

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR

THE GREAT OUTDOORS
People play volleyball during 'digital detox' hours in Mohityanche Vadgaon

to wind down after a hard day's work, they would scroll through social media, watching the latest prime-time show or daily soap operas on the TV. Not anymore. Now, as the evening siren goes off, the villagers, mostly farmers or sugar mill workers, have to get off their screens, be it the television or mobile phone, for the next hour and a half. Children can use the time to study, youngsters can read, or people can simply spend some quality time with each other or with their families. It has been nine months now since the 3,500-odd residents of the village have been practising this daily 'digital detox', so much so that it has inspired the neighbouring villages to follow suit.

"For two years after the pandemic began, children were confined to their homes," says Vijay Mohite, the former sarpanch of Mohityanche Vadgaon. "Students attended school online, which meant that for over an hour and a half, they were glued to their mobile screens. Even families that were not well-off had to buy a smartphone for their children. However, this habit persisted well after offline classes restarted." The screen time of the adults, too, had shot up, and its fallout became evident when social and familial interactions and children's learning outcomes, as well as their health, started getting affected. Children were getting irritable and threw tantrums when parents took their phones. "What was more worrying was that they could surf the internet and access content inappropriate for their age," says Mohite. Teachers in the village also expressed concern about children's screen addiction and the declining attention span in the classroom. The qualitative decline was obvious, and measures like appointing private tutors or conducting extra classes were also not yielding results.

It was then that Mohite decided to try a community-wide 'digital detox'. "In rural areas, houses are smaller and children have no separate rooms per se to study. Often, they are forced to study in the same room where the TV is on, which distracts them. The 7-8.30 pm slot was chosen because it is prime time and that's when daily soaps and dramas are aired," says Mohite.

The members of the village came around to the idea soon enough, and on August 15, 2022, India's 75th Independence Day, Mohityanche Vadgaon became the first village in the country to go on a collective detox. Some did flout the digital curfew initially. So, a squad was set up to locate and warn these defaulters. Some of the children also did not hesitate to tell on recalcitrant elders in the family. Violators were threatened with a fine, but it was never actually levied. "After a week or so, the people themselves realised the benefits of the initiative," says Mohite.

Sushma Misal, a Class 10 student in the village, is one of them. "Initially," she says, "I found it difficult to keep my mobile aside or deal with the television being switched off, and would start using my phone a few minutes before 8.30 pm. But gradually, the digital detox grew on me. I am confident of getting better marks in my Class 10 examinations because of this."

RESIDENTS OF MOHITYANCHE VADGAON SAY THAT THEIR QUALITY OF LIFE HAS IMPROVED SINCE THE DIGITAL DETOX

M.A. Mane, principal of the Vidyarthi Vikas Vidyalaya High School, which has around 450 students, says that learning outcomes have improved. "Students take the initiative now and study on their own," he says. The school, on the whole, has seen a qualitative improvement. In fact, teachers say concentration levels and attention spans have visibly improved. So much so, students from neighbouring villages like Asad and Ambag have voluntarily adopted the detox regimen.

Many villagers claim that they have either cut down their overall TV usage or have stopped seeing it altogether. Abhijit Mohite, 23, who recently completed his master's degree in science, says, "Earlier, there was no designated time for students to study.... Now that televisions are switched off at prime time, people speak to each other at home and there is a sense of belonging. These conversations were stunted earlier as life revolved around television shows."

Pratik Mohite, 27, who has a master's degree in alcohol technology and works at a distillery in a sugar factory, says that though there are no children in his house, the initiative has helped him stay off the screen